

“Real’ Men” Are Ideological

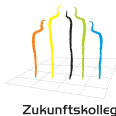
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Roadmap

① Introduction

② Analytical background

③ Semantics of the “real”

④ Extensions

What is ‘real’?

- Who counts as a ‘real man’?
- Or a ‘real’ anything?

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- Who counts as a ‘real man’?
- Or a ‘real’ anything?
- What is the relationship between stereotype, denotation, and the ideologies that underpin stereotypical notions?
- And how do these elements appear in the compositional semantics of terms in different languages?

Our talk

Some more background questions: How does language encode the means to talk about stereotypes? How does this relate to the broader notion of ideology and ideologically loaded language? What has this to do with normality? And with normativity?

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The foil: the common English expression *real NP*

- (1) Real men don't eat salad.
- (2) Real women wear lipstick. (Haslanger 2011)
- (3) A real woman is not boisterous or loud in her actions but is characterized by a gentle and quiet spirit. (from Leslie 2015)

Our contention

According to our proposal:

- *real* in (1) has a meaning similar to other stereotypical adjectives in a variety of languages...
- (in particular, to *rashii* in Japanese, our starting point)
- ...but is also interpreted relative to an *ideology* .
- (1) will have a meaning like the following: “*individuals who have a sufficient number of stereotypical properties associated with man by a particular ideology are such that they don’t eat salad.*”

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rashii

Our analysis extends the work of McCready and Ogata 2007a,b on Japanese propositional & noun-modifying *rashii*

- *rashii* attached to full clauses $\leadsto$ evidential meaning
- *rashii* attached to NP_i $\leadsto$ its argument satisfies some stereotype relating to NP_i

- (4) ame-ga furu rashii
rain-Nom fall RASHII
'It seems that it will rain.'
- (5) Hanako-wa totemo onna-rashii
Hanako-Top very woman-RASHII
'Hanako is very womanly/feminine'

rashii 2

Can one unify these two uses?

- Both indicate that something satisfies a sufficient number of ‘standard’ properties to enable a judgement.
 - *ame-ga furu rashii* ~ ‘some bit of evidence has raised the subjective probability of rain to a sufficiently high degree’ (McCready and Ogata 2007b)
 - [[onna rashii] (hito)] ‘woman RASHII person’ means something like “(person) exemplifies certain properties stereotypically associated with women”
- propositional case: ‘stereotypical’ properties are those properties of worlds/situations that can be used as evidence for the prejacent, ie. which are ‘canonically’ associated with it.

rashii 3

There is thus a high-level similarity between propositional and nominal-modifying *rashii*.

- This led eg. Saito (2004) to treat them as closely semantically related.
- But – clearly – one of these is a more ‘objective’ judgement than the other:
 - proposition-modifying *rashii* involves genuine evidential support (in a Bayesian sense),
 - while NP-modifying *rashii* is mostly stereotype-referencing.
- This is so even for less socially laden terms: *tonkatsu rashii*
tonkatsu picks out something like the Platonic ideal of a pork cutlet according to some culinary norm/stereotype.

We thus put the project of unification aside for now; we reconsider the question at the end of the talk.

rashii and *real*

Our proposal:

- *real NP* has the same kernel of meaning as *NP rashii*...
- ...but also requires reference to *an ideology*.
 - (the Japanese case does as well, a point missed by M&O (and others, eg. Saito 2004))

To implement, we make a simple technical adjustment to M&O's framework: **relativization to ideologies**.

- following Henderson and McCready (2021, 2024), we model as ordered pairs $\iota = \langle \rho, \mathcal{B} \rangle$, where:
 - ρ is an affect assigning function (mapping entities to real numbers, representing the affective value assigned by a person to that entity)
 - $\mathcal{B}$ is an ideological base, a set of propositions representing the belief component of ideologies

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Deriving the meaning ingredients for “real”

Basic ingredient: a set of stereotypical properties associated with some predicate P (for concreteness, think *men*). Here's how M&O get that.

- 1 Start with a set of individuals, Q , defined:

$$\llbracket Q \rrbracket_M = \{a \in D \mid \text{for all } g.M, g[a/x] \models Q(x)\}$$

- 2 We use “normality conditionals” ($A >_a B$) to get a set of stereotypical properties.
 - ~ “if A , then normally B , according to agent a ”
 - (cf. Delgrande 1988; Asher and Morreau 1995)
- 3 Use these ingredients to get the set of properties normally possessed by P (according to a):

$$(6) \quad A_{a,M}(P) = \{\llbracket Q \rrbracket_M \mid M \models \forall x[P(x) >_a Q(x)]\}$$

More ingredients

- ④ Wrinkle: $A(P)$ includes both *essential* and *non-essential* properties
- Want to remove the *essential* properties from the domain of quantification of the adjectives
 - Why? So we don't e.g. have *has-a-circulatory-system* in our stereotypical *man*-properties
- ⑤ We use the set of necessary properties $C_M(P)$ (see (7)) to filter the properties in $A(P)$...
- ⑥ ...yielding the stereotypical properties of P s, $S(P)$, via (8).

$$(7) \quad C_M(P) = \{ \llbracket Q \rrbracket_M \mid \text{for all } M, g \models \forall x \Box [P(x) \rightarrow Q(x)] \}$$

$$(8) \quad S(P) = A(P) \setminus C(P)$$

More ingredients

- ⑦ $S(P)$ can be used to talk about the stereotypical properties associated with a property, that are satisfied by a particular individual, by using the function CS , which returns the stereotypical- P -properties x has.

$$(9) \quad CS(P)(x) = \{P' \in S(P) \mid P'(x) = 1\}$$

Example: John Wayne, I

- Where the individual we are interested in is John Wayne, j ,
- and the property is *being-American*,
- $CS(\text{American})(jw)$ yields the set of stereotypically American properties John Wayne has.

This allows us to view *John Wayne is a real man* as an implicit comparative construction:

“John Wayne has more stereotypical man-properties than the salient benchmark”

(much as *JW is tall* says that he has more tallness than the contextual standard)

Example: John Wayne, II

⑧ For this, we define a function γ , as below.

$$(10) \quad \gamma_{\langle \langle \langle e, t \rangle, t \rangle, d \rangle} = \lambda Q_{\langle \langle e, t \rangle t \rangle} . [|Q|]$$

(γ takes a set of properties as argument, and gives the cardinality of the set as a value, which we treat as degrees as in Kennedy 2007)

⑨ Then, we employ Kennedy's s , a function from measure functions to degrees that yield a contextual standard.

⑩ *John Wayne is a real man* becomes (11).

⑪ (1) is analyzed, accordingly, as (12).

$$(11) \quad \gamma(CS)(man)(jw) \succ s(S(man))$$

$$(12) \quad \forall x [[\gamma(CS)(man)(x) \succ s(S(man))] \rightarrow \neg \text{EatSalad}(x)]$$

Adding ideology to the mix

Ideology is needed here $\leadsto$ no notion of a ‘real man (/woman)’ (or *onna rashii hito*) that isn’t ideology-dependent: the very idea depends on what one’s ideals of masculinity (/femininity) are, and those come directly from ideological belief.

- 12 So, relativize the above construction to *an ideology*, ι .
- $>_a$ is defined in terms of a normality ranking on worlds, $\leq_a$, based on what a takes to be normal.
 - “ a ” here goes proxy for the agent a ’s default assumptions about the world—effectively, their information state.
- 13 Since (following H&M), $\iota = \langle \rho, \mathcal{B} \rangle$, we need only use $\mathcal{B}$ to impose the ordering relative to which the normality conditional is defined.

- 14 So, we define $\leq$ relative to an ideology with epistemic base $\mathcal{B}$ as follows.

$$w_1 \leq_{\mathcal{B}} w_2 \text{ iff } \{p \in \mathcal{B} \mid w_1 \in p\} \supseteq \{p \in \mathcal{B} \mid w_2 \in p\}.$$

A world then ranks higher if it makes more of the ideological beliefs in $\mathcal{B}$ true.

(6) can then be redefined as follows, relativizing it to $\mathcal{B}$.

$$(13) \quad A_{a,M}(P) = \{\llbracket Q \rrbracket_M \mid M \models \forall x[P(x) >_{\mathcal{B}} Q(x)]\}$$

Lexical entry

We can now give the following lexical entry for *real*.

$$(14) \quad \llbracket \text{real} \rrbracket = \lambda P \lambda x \partial P(x).[\gamma(CS(P)(x))]$$

This lexical entry is essentially similar to that given by McCready and Ogata (2007a) for *rashii*; like *rashii*, *real* imposes the presupposition that its argument satisfies its property argument.

Real men are presupposed to be men, as seen in (15), which requires the addressee to be a man; other semantic operators like negation behave similarly.

$$(15) \quad \text{If you were a real man, you wouldn't eat quiche.} \quad \Rightarrow \quad \text{man}(a)$$

Further restrictions on the real

The stereotypical ‘real N’ construction has some other effects/restrictions.

- It implies a positive evaluation of Ns ~ the stereotypes associated with Ns by the relevant ideology.
- ‘Real men like to chew tobacco’ implies that the speaker positively evaluates such men.
- Consequence: Ns with an inherent negative evaluation aren’t felicitous in the stereotype-referencing ‘real N’ construction, as with slurs or other negative terms.

(16) # Real assholes don’t pay the tab.

(17) # Real tra****s wear proper makeup.

Reclamation

The last point holds when pejorative / slur / negative term is genuinely interpreted negatively.

- Reclamation: phenomenon in which a slur is used by members of the slurred group (as eg. a mechanism of solidarity).
- Use of ‘real S’ sounds much better when S is interpreted positively:

(18) Real queers show solidarity with other oppressed people.

- This is so even for e.g. ‘asshole’ as in (16): improved if speaker is read as approving, as if they are recommending the behavior in question.

Upshot: positive (non-negative?) evaluation is genuinely required.

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Extension 1: dual character concepts

Our proposal touches on the hotly debated topic of **dual character concepts** (DCCs, Knobe et al. 2013; Reuter 2019).

Phenomenon whereby certain terms (typically of social kinds, e.g., *artist*, etc.) are associated with two different dimensions of categorization:

- a **descriptive** dimension: descriptive criteria (an *artist* is someone who produces works of art professionally)
- a **normative** or **ideal** dimension: appeals to ideals associated with the kind (an *artist* pursues aesthetic value over commercial gain)

Extension 1: dual character concepts

Noteworthy behavior of DCCs → possible double dissociation between normative and descriptive senses:

- “She is an artist, but if you think about what an artist really is, she’s not an artist.”

(Said about a profit-seeking professional artist.)

- “She’s not an artist, but if you think about what an artist really is, she is an artist after all.”

(Said about a person who produces no paradigmatic artwork, but respects and pursues aesthetic value.)

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(Said about a person who produces no paradigmatic artwork, but respects and pursues aesthetic value.)

The *real NP* frame has been claimed to evoke the normative dimension (see Leslie 2015):

- *Real artists* don’t tailor their work to whatever is trending.

DCCs and our analysis

Previous accounts construe this behavior as evidence of polysemy in the NP.

- Leslie 2015 $\leadsto$ a certain class of common nouns are polysemous; have descriptive and normative senses.
- Del Pinal 2018 $\leadsto$ normative interpretations are the result of sense modulation that targets certain features of an N's lexical entry.

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Our account:

- normative interpretation the result of *real*'s meaning contribution
- fewer assumptions/ commitments about the lexicon
- more liberal in one sense: in principle, any NP can express “normative sense”
 - “That's not *real coffee*!”
- more constrained in another: its availability depends on antecedent ideological beliefs

DCCs via ideology selection

Compare our account with Leslie's:

- Which common nouns have both descriptive and normative senses?
- Unclear, but they tend to be for kind terms admitting of more or less well-defined “social roles”.
 - *artist, doctor, friend*, etc.
 - precisely those nouns identified by the DCC literature.
- But not exclusively. (Cf. Leslie's “bus driver” example.)
- Other than this observation, the proposed polysemy is rather unconstrained.

On our account, origin of “normative” reading is less mysterious *and* more constrained. *Real NP* will only be interpretable if it is coherent to interpret relative to particular ideology *about* the kind denoted by the NP.

Against lexical enrichment

Del Pinal account assumes a complex lexicon (cf. GL/Pustejovsky).

- ‘real’ introduces an operator returning content from the ‘functional’ dimension of the lexical item’s C-structure (cf. GL’s TELIC) and content from the ‘normative’ dimension.
- It is quite nonstandard to assume a ‘normative’ dimension that’s part of any account of lexical meaning.
- Still: assume it exists. What then determines the content of the normative dimension? Presumably, something like ideologies; so both accounts appeal to them anyway.
- But is all this best couched as a claim about the structure of the lexicon? Better, we think: leave ideology as something that can be introduced via standard modal underspecification.

DCCs and liberality

Our account is more liberal than the others:

- Provided an ideology about the kind denoted by the NP is salient,...
- ...any kind can be appealed to in the *real NP* frame.
- Maybe some kind terms (b/c of the ideologies associated with them) lend themselves quite easily to this formulation:
 - *real friends, real artists, real men, etc.*
- But given an antecedent salient ideology, (almost) any kind term can work:
 - *real coffee, real syntactician, real taxis*
- This is a feature, not a bug: there is no fixed list of DCCs, and they can be created quite freely and spontaneously (Knobe)

Extension 2: focus reduplication

Our view extends to other linguistic phenomena involving stereotypical reference like **focus reduplication**.

- “This is the SALAD salad” (Ghomeshi et al. 2004)

In some cases, there is no need for the introduction of an explicit element either, as in:

- “MEN_F don’t eat quiche”

Uttered with the right intonation, also has the stereotypical/ideological reading.

Restrictions on reduplication

There are contrasts in the availability of reduplication.

- Foodstuffs are ok: *COFFEE* coffee, *SALAD* salad
- Social roles are ok: *DOCTOR* doctor, *COP* cop
- But at least many natural kind terms are out (or so it seems to us): *MAN* man, *WOMAN* woman

Why should this be?

Salience and alternatives

Perhaps it's just a question of how salient the alternatives are?

- In good cases, the ideological target and the alternatives are pretty clear.
- $[[\text{doctor}]]_{alt} = \text{person with a phd vs medical doctor};$
- $[[\text{salad}]]_{alt} = \text{potato salad vs something with lots of greens}.$

But in the bad cases, they are unobvious. (What is the interpretative alternative to ‘man’ here?)

- Prediction: ‘MAN man’ cases improve if there is a salient alternative set. (e.g: transphobia?)

Evaluativeness

Evaluativity also appears to play a role, just as with ‘real.’

- ‘SLUR slur’ sounds generally bad.
- If alterantive salience story is right: ‘SLUR slur’ requires both the ideologically positive and negative alternatives to be salient
- This presupposes that there is an ideologically positive alternative which SLUR can refer to.... but there is not.
- Possible prediction: focus reduplication might work with reclaimed slurs, because of the availability of alternatives.

This prediction seems to us to be correct.

Focus reduplication, compositionally

If all this is on the right track, there looks to us to be a route to a compositional account of these cases.

- There is as yet no such account in the literature, to our knowledge.
- One can imagine various ways to introduce something like the denotation of ‘real’ above via stipulation, but none are very attractive.
- But, if reduplication induces generation of a set of alternatives which are then subject to a covert comparative, a cleaner account that derives the phenomenon and its restrictions might be available.
- The sticking point would be doing so in a fully nonstipulative manner.

We leave this complex problem for future work.

Focus and adjectives: overt evaluative structure

While we leave the compositional analysis of English *real* for future work, we want to point out that cross-linguistic evidence suggests that the structure we are implicitly appealing to is not idiosyncratic.

In a number of languages, the evaluative component that English can leave implicit is expressed **overtly** by an adjective such as *strong*, *real*, or *good*.

- These adjectives make explicit the comparison that the English construction only implicitly suggests and induce the generation of a set of alternatives overtly.
- Hebrew and Palestinian Arabic illustrate this particularly clearly: bare generics often sound descriptive, while the normative reading is licensed by an overt evaluative adjective.

Focus and adjectives: Hebrew

Bare generic (possible, often descriptive):

gvarim lo bochim

men NEG *cry*.PL

“Men don’t cry.”

Normative reading with overt adjective:

gvarim chazakim lo bochim

men strong.PL NEG *cry*.PL

“Strong men don’t cry.”

Focus and adjectives: Palestinian Arabic

Plural (possible, often descriptive):

il-wlād mā bibku

the-boys NEG *cry.PL*

“Boys don’t cry.”

Normative reading with overt adjective:

il-wlād il-awiyā mā bibku

the-boys the-strong NEG *cry.PL*

“Strong boys don’t cry.”

Focus and adjectives: Palestinian Arabic

Singular (contrast, especially clear):

il-walad mā bibki

The-boy neg cry.m.sg

“The boy isn’t crying.”

il-walad il-awi mā bibki

The-boy the-strong neg cry.m.sg

“A strong boy doesn’t cry.”

Generalization: The covert comparative over focus alternatives we posited for English is simply realized overtly in languages where the evaluative standard must be lexically expressed.

Broader implications

Our analysis also has interesting broader implications because of the minimal view of ideology we use.

- Any set of beliefs can be viewed as an ideology...
- In a certain sense all speech is normative relative to an ideology
 - including definitional generics like ‘Tomatoes are fruits’ (Krifka 2013)
- Formally speaking, all these can have an ideological basis in our sense, as they are stated relative to a belief set, namely the speaker’s information state (or world-model) as assumed in the classical literature on normative conditionals.
- In the same sense, the analysis implies that ordinary commonsense linguistic and philosophical analysis is also normative, reinforcing claims made by many in the recent philosophical literature (Beaver and Stanley 2023; Keiser 2023).

That's it for now!

Thank you!!

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- Evidence is evidence relative to a belief set (world-model). Perhaps what counts as evidence also has a stereotypical component.

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This is a project for future research.